1 | A radical history of development studies: individuals, institutions and ideologies

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Why a radical history of development studies?

This book provides radical, historically informed readings of the emergence, trajectories and interpretations of international development. It presents a critical genealogy of development studies through exploring changes in discourses about development and examining the contested evolution and role of development institutions by focusing upon the recollections of those who teach, research and practise development. These accounts challenge the dominant, modernist narrative that posits a singular, unilinear trajectory and present alternative versions of ideas and institutions, and the people that embody them. The book shows how the work of individuals and institutions engaged in contemporary development studies cannot be properly understood without adequate historical contextualization. Accordingly, the chapters presented in this volume will attempt to understand why and how international development, generally, and development studies, specifically, have evolved.

This is a radical chronicle because it includes plural conceptions of development history and adopts a critical perspective towards, and engagement with, orthodoxies of development theory and practice. Each chapter, moreover, is radical in at least one of two other senses – first, by highlighting those concealed, critical discourses that have been written out of conventional stories of development or marginalized in mainstream accounts of ideas that have influenced contemporary understandings of development thought; second, in that their critique of ideas and practices of development is founded upon, and emerged out of, thinking from the 'left'. In this book these radical interpretations are represented by, for example, Marxist, post-colonial and feminist perspectives and analyses.

With a few notable exceptions the history often rehearsed in development research and teaching has tended towards a compartmentalization of clearly bounded, successive periods characterized by specific theoretical hegemonies that articulate a singular theoretical genealogy. Typically, the story commences with economic growth and modernization theories, moves on to discuss theories of 'underdevelopment', and culminates in neo-liberalism and the Washington Consensus (see Hettne 1995; Preston 1996). This periodization,

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moreover, is mapped on to particular events and processes, most notably with the reification of 1945 as the key year in which development was initiated owing to the establishment of the World Bank and other Bretton Woods institutions. Recent critical explorations, from post-colonial, postmodern and feminist perspectives, have undoubtedly provided important challenges to orthodox development chronologies but they have to varying degrees continued to conform to the same periodization (Marchand and Parpart 1995; Rist 1997; Kothari and Minogue 2001), as have those that present alternative visions of development (Munck and O'Hearn 1999; Rahnema and Bawtree 1997). To counter these trends and develop the longer historical perspectives and alternative readings of the origins and evolution of development taken by Jonathan Crush (1995) and Cowen and Shenton (1996), the chapters in this book highlight how bounded classifications and epochal historicizations not only obscure a longer genealogy of development but also undermine attempts to demonstrate historical continuities and divergences in the theory and practice of development, compounding the concealment of ongoing critiques. They underscore how this limited analysis reveals the largely unreflexive nature of the field of study, partly engendered through the imperative to achieve development goals and targets.

By providing different understandings of the growth of development studies, this book subverts a mainstream unilinear history and moves beyond a periodization of theoretical positions. More broadly, by using development studies as a case study, some of the chapters challenge ideas about discourse and power by questioning particular notions of what constitutes development and the 'Third World', and interrogate our understandings of the interrelationship between what Stuart Hall (1996) refers to as the 'West and the Rest'. In critiquing orthodox ideas, challenging normative representations and highlighting both continuities and divergences over time and across space, they disrupt the projection of a singular record of the past. These understandings are essential to identify how the present is informed by the past and to further recognize that history can enable a (re)visioning of future strategies for change.

While the importance of reflexively tracing the evolution of their disciplines has recently been acknowledged by some within, for example, anthropology and geography, understanding the implications of the past is not a mainstream preoccupation within development studies. This volume represents an attempt at exploring the history of development studies as a multi-disciplinary subject that emerged in the post-war era of decolonization, but was also informed by antecedent influences. It takes a multi-methodological and holistic approach by weaving together different narratives, including personal recol-

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lections of working in development studies, histories of particular themes, such as gender, social development and natural resources within development studies, and genealogies of development institutions such as the World Bank. Some of the chapters redirect attention towards ideas, ideologies and concepts in a field that for some time has been characterized by more practical and technical concerns. The insistence on the link between past and present, and adopting a radical appreciation of a range of perspectives, will (it is hoped) mark a significant moment in the critical reconfiguration of development studies.

Understanding development studies

Understandings of the nature and concept of development studies are as varied, multiple and contentious as definitions of what constitutes development itself. Indeed, particular perceptions of what constitutes development studies are linked to, and often embedded in, particular notions about what development is.

That development studies is open to varying and contesting interpretations is evident from ongoing discussions among those in relevant academic departments, institutions and associations. There are diverse views concerning what development studies is or should be, ranging from opinions as to whether it is primarily about academic research or more concerned with policy and practical relevance, whether it possesses a specific epistemology and methodology, and the extent to which it is multi-disciplinary, inter-disciplinary or cross-disciplinary. These contesting points of view reflect competing understandings about the purpose of development and the nature of the relationship between theories and ideologies, policies and practices. Furthermore, they highlight the various insights into, and perspectives on, the genealogy of development.

Significantly, these issues have cohered around debates on the distinctiveness of development studies as a field of academic study. There is general agreement that development studies cannot claim to be a distinct and separate academic discipline in the same way as, for instance, economics or geography, partly because it is a relatively new field of study. Rather it is cross-disciplinary, engaging with different bodies of theory, conceptual and methodological frameworks, and understandings of policy relevance and practical implications. It is this borrowing and application of ideas from different disciplines that to some extent provides the distinctive characteristics of development studies. A series of articles in *World Development* (2002) explores this issue of cross-disciplinarity, a generic term relating to forms of analysis that are substantially based on theories, concepts and methods of

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more than one discipline (see Kanbur 2002). Inter-disciplinary partnerships have proved difficult to achieve, however, and development studies can be more accurately described as multi-disciplinary. Although various disciplines are brought together in development studies and share the same academic space, and despite attempts to identify its epistemological and methodological distinctiveness (see Sumner and Tribe 2004), there has been limited success in producing truly hybrid theories, methodologies or practices.

While development studies cannot be identified as a discrete academic discipline there is a broad convergence among those in the 'community' on shared concerns and objectives. For example, there is some agreement about what the object/subject of study should be and what foundational theories and concepts students of development should be familiar with. Most commonly, development studies is seen to be concerned with processes of change in so-called 'Third World' or 'developing countries', and more recently this has been widened to encompass transitional economies. For some, there is also a narrowing of focus on studies of poverty and poverty alleviation while others have become increasingly concerned with socio-economic dimensions of global inequities and exclusionary processes. There remains, however, an ongoing debate as to the overwhelming importance of practice in relation to theory. In a paper on the irrelevance of development studies, Michael Edwards (1989) directly addresses this issue and argues that research within development studies is often abstract and divorced from development in practice and the realities of poor people. Thus, he contends, to understand development problems requires being involved in the process of development itself, thereby strengthening the links between research and action. The continuing relevance of this debate about research and practice is, in part, engendered by the legacy of the original context of post-independence development studies. When many development studies institutes were first established, those involved were primarily concerned with policy formulation and the technical and practical measures required to implement economic and social change, and accordingly spent much of their time overseas. This theory/practice divide, or what Sumner and Tribe (2004) refer to as the divergence between 'discourse-related' and 'instrumental/empirical-oriented' categories of development studies, has become exacerbated as alternative strands in development studies are increasingly uneasy with what is seen as the over-emphasis on planning change without significant identification and critique of the ideologies that underpin these standard policies and practices.

To clarify these points, Alan Thomas (2004) suggests that as the definition of 'development' adopted varies, so does the viewpoint concerning what development studies is *about* or *for*. His typology of the relationship between ideas

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about development and ensuing definitions of development studies, which is presented below, explores further this issue of what should be studied and from what viewpoint.

Development as:	Development studies is:
Visions or measures of progressive change	*About* development: debating what is desirable or progressive for society; understanding human needs; measuring dimensions of poverty and 'development' (philosophy, psychology, economics, statistics, etc.).
Historical change process	*About* development: knowing about lives, livelihoods, social relations, etc., in different parts of the world and how they have changed; understanding, debating and applying theories of social change at local and global levels (history, sociology, political science, economics and anthropology).
Deliberate efforts at progress	*About* development: knowing about types of development agent, concepts of trusteeship, accountability; understanding the architecture of policy and governance locally and globally (social policy, organization studies, political science).
	For development: building skills and competencies for development policy and management (management, public administration, policy studies); empowering through study; building attitudes and skills of participation, lobbying and activism (development education, organization development, community development).

Source: Thomas (2004)

It is the interrelationship between theories, ideas and histories of development policy and practice which makes the identity of development as a subject of study so complicated and contested. There are those who feel that the study of development is most closely connected to ideas about social, economic and political change, while others are informed by a more instrumental goal of shaping policy and a practical concern with the implementation and evaluation of development interventions. Thus, there is disagreement as to where development studies should be located along a continuum from intellectual analyses and interpretations of processes of change to 'doing development'

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utilizing the practical skills and techniques associated with transformation on the ground. Those who draw a parallel with the emergence of social policy as an academic discipline suggest that influencing, formulating and implementing policy must guide development studies. For example, Raymond Apthorpe suggests that development studies should be thought of as poverty or policy studies, and that 'changing from Development Studies to Poverty Studies offers an opportunity to incorporate ideas and methodologies from other disciplines into the social analysis of poverty' (1999: 535). These reflections on analysing and doing development – or *about* and *for* development – are at the heart of attempts to define development studies.

Michael Burawoy's (2004a) thought-provoking article on the disciplinary division of labour in sociology is particularly useful to those wrestling with the dilemmas involved in identifying coherent yet diverse development studies. Burawoy identifies four interdependent sociologies – policy, professional, critical and public – and makes the case that these are not 'alternatives but necessary complements'. He constructs a disciplinary matrix, reproduced below, while acknowledging that the boundaries between the different fields are often blurred, individuals can have multiple interests, and priorities vary between academic institutions, and over time.

	Academic audience	Extra-academic audience
Instrumental knowledge	Professional	Policy
Reflexive knowledge	Critical	Public

Source: Burawoy (2004b)

Burawoy (2004b) contrasts different audiences and different forms of knowledge and suggests that professional and policy work are primarily instrumental forms of knowledge 'inasmuch as they are concerned with orienting means to given ends, namely puzzle solving in professional research that takes for granted the presumptions of a given research program, and problem solving in the policy arena that takes for granted the goals and interests of the client'. He envisages critical and public fields as reflexive forms of knowledge that are oriented 'to a dialogue about assumptions, values, premises' among those in the discipline and with the public.

Applying this sort of disciplinary matrix to development studies could provide a useful starting point for identifying and appreciating the interconnectedness of the diverse range of activities, and perspectives, that come

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under its rubric. A discussion of this kind is imperative given the shifting local and global context in which development currently takes place. The chapters in this book, in various ways, contribute to this debate by demonstrating, for example, that development studies is not only about describing and understanding planned interventions but also about analysing discourses of development and seriously interrogating processes of socio-economic, political and institutional change. Not all contributors see their research as having direct policy and practical relevance but rather as providing the very necessary critiques and analyses of them. Development studies must, therefore, create opportunities to carry out policy-relevant research and devise methodologies and practical tools for development interventions, as well as a space for critical and radical academic investigation of ideas and histories.

Some of the authors challenge the dichotomies between 'studying' and 'doing' development that have been alluded to above, while others reaffirm these dualisms by emphasizing the distinct roles of theory and practice. Whatever their position, however, collectively these chapters provide further evidence for the importance of historically analysing the nature of development studies and exploring the ways in which development works both in and against its past. Despite their different and occasionally divergent conceptions of development studies, they provide a critique of, and challenge to, mainstream and orthodox notions of development and versions of its history.

What the book says

The histories of the institutions, ideas and individuals associated with development provide the focus for the analysis of development studies presented in this book. It is through these interconnected subjects that a radical and critical history of development is mapped out, continuities and divergences recognized and parallel histories remembered. This radical take on the archaeology and genealogy of development draws upon readings, from a range of viewpoints, that challenge established accounts of how development studies emerged, its priorities and ideological basis. The chapters link micro and macro levels of analyses, demonstrate how the past and present are imbricated and explore the relationship between personal experience, ideas and institutions of development. Some of the authors effectively weave their own personal narratives into the history of development studies as they map their individual trajectories on the development landscape. Producing stories of travel, networks, flows and relationships forged and maintained over time and space, they highlight the interconnectedness of ideologies, institutions and individuals that is arguably peculiar to development studies.

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The authors who have contributed to this volume are, or have been, variously involved in a range of activities that include policy advice and technical assistance for non-governmental and governmental agencies, secondments to bilateral and multilateral organizations, consultancy work and funded academic research or that supported by bilateral donors. Some are first and foremost academics, involved in teaching and researching in development studies, while others see themselves primarily as advocates, practitioners and activists. Despite the variety of the forms of our engagement with the development industry, most of us are based in, or affiliated to, academic institutions. Although our academic backgrounds are located within the more traditional social science disciplines, we now work in multi-disciplinary departments or institutes of development studies. The increasing focus on research and teaching and the reduction in long periods of secondment overseas have changed the nature of development studies, and this is reflected in some of the histories presented in the book.

That this book is overwhelmingly UK focused is itself a reflection of the origins of development studies and particularly a colonial legacy of ideas concerning progress, modernity and trusteeship. In North America and much of western Europe studies of development in the main take place either within traditional social science disciplines or in area studies. In the UK, there were numerous sub-fields of, for example, development economics, the sociology of development, anthropology and development and development geography, and although these are still evident there has, since the late 1980s, been a tendency for development studies to be concentrated in specialized multi-disciplinary centres. While the case for highlighting the beginnings in the UK justifies the focus, we hope that this book opens the door for subsequent critical histories of development studies, especially from those located in parts of the world that have for long been the subject of the (Western) development gaze, yet are also significant agents of change and critics of development.

The body of the book is divided into two parts. The first presents personal recollections of working in development studies which highlight the emergence of development institutions and changes in the theory and practice of development over time. The colonial legacy of development is explored in this section, together with the political and personal tensions of working for development agencies. The second part begins with histories of radical ideologies of development, informed by Marxist critiques, that present parallel histories to those rehearsed in mainstream accounts. Other chapters in this section trace the path of ideas and ideologies of discourses on gender and development, natural resources and environmentalism, and non-governmental

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organizations, uncovering when and how they emerged and have transformed over time.

The book begins with a chapter by John Harriss, who describes and evaluates key trends in the history of development studies, combining his personal history as the 'first student of development studies' with a history of the people and ideas that have shaped the nature of the 'discipline'. He divides the history of development studies into three moments, those of promise, hubris and recovery, arguing that while development studies began with high ambitions, these were crushed in the 1980s with the onslaught of economic liberalism. Amid the hubris of that period, however, there were the roots of a recovery, though one that is not yet quite certain. The essay concludes with some assessment of the present paths of development studies, arguing that the challenge now lies not so much in resisting the critiques that derive from postmodernism as in renewing the discipline's relevance through improved historical understanding of development, and of the moral and practical requirements of global justice.

Although John Harriss's version of the history of development studies focuses primarily on the post-war period, he does acknowledge the legacy of colonialism, a theme that is developed in the following two chapters by Uma Kothari and Robert Chambers. Uma Kothari is concerned with a colonialism that 'survives the demise of empires' (Nandy 1998) and provides a post-colonial analysis of continuities and divergences over time. More specifically, the chapter focuses on the transition from colonialism to development and is, in part, based on the personal narratives of individuals whose experiences bridge and overlap this historical shift. These interviews with former colonial officers who subsequently worked in development studies institutes of higher education provide one historical method for uncovering and understanding the varied articulations of the transition from 'colonialism' to 'development cooperation', and the ongoing relationship between colonial forms of rule and governance and the purpose and practice of development. The chapter argues that mainstream development studies tends to conceal its colonial past and thus, perhaps unwittingly, creates a dichotomy between a colonialism that is 'bad', exploitative, extractive and oppressive and a development that is 'good', moralistic, philanthropic and humanitarian. In this way the apparent 'goodness' that inheres in development goes unquestioned.

Robert Chambers presents a personal history which begins with a period overseas as part of the Colonial Service. He reflects on his experiences as a colonial administrator and his involvement in former colonies after independence while based at the Institute for Development Studies at the University of Sussex. He describes how he has always felt on the margins of mainstream

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development as an 'undisciplined non-economist'. He uses his experiences to reflect on what we do and how we do it in development studies, while recognizing that his story presents an idiosyncratic view. He concludes with a radical agenda for the future of development studies, advocating greater methodological awareness and critical reflexivity. In the final analysis Chambers argues that those working in development studies should become more nomadic 'to avoid the traps of isolation, insulation and complacency' and develop a greater facility for analysing the powerful and their actions.

Teresa Hayter, in Chapter 5, offers another personal story, but this time one that is connected with development institutions. The chapter reflects tensions and conflict as she narrates her attempts to challenge the World Bank and expose the divergence between what it says it is doing and what it actually does. The chapter focuses on her experiences of carrying out research on, and with, the World Bank from the 1960s to the 1980s, and some of the difficulties associated with publicizing her findings.

The second part of the book presents a history of ideas about development. Some chapters provide alternative versions while others invoke forgotten or marginalized histories. The section begins with a chapter by Henry Bernstein that considers the relationship between development studies and Marxism and some of the tensions that each brings to their encounters. These are sketched in terms of two conjunctures and the passage between them. The first incorporates the founding moment of development studies as an academic specialism in the 1950s and 1960s, a time of intense political and intellectual contestation additionally fuelled by the strong revival and development of Marxism in universities in the 1960s and 1970s. The second proposes some paradoxes about development studies from the 1980s with the ascendancy, then hegemony, of neo-liberal ideas. The first paradox is that whereby less (interventionism) prescribed by development doctrine becomes more (expanding political, social and cultural conditions for markets to work effectively); the second that whereby more, that is an expanding agenda, becomes less owing to the intellectual and political constraints of neo-liberal hegemony. The chapter argues that this second conjuncture also incorporates the challenges to Marxism presented by the demise of any extant examples of socialist development and other manifestations of political defeat in a period of apparently untrammelled globalization of capital.

John Cameron also invokes Marxism, in the following chapter, as he explores studies of poverty through his research publications over a period of thirty years. He suggests that the early 1970s were a high point in neo-Marxian development research, partly because this agenda could engage with the

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emerging basic-needs approaches that marked the key shift in development discourse during this period. The reassertion and dominance of neo-liberal principles and practices in the 1980s, however, demanded defensive reviews of ideas and principles associated with pro-poor research. This led to an uneasy engagement with post-structural and critical realist thinking in the 1990s which remains unresolved, although they could stimulate development thinking beyond simplistic anti-neo-liberalism. This journey is traced through the author's publications accompanied by reflections on what links them in terms of their ontological, epistemological and teleological coherence.

The following three chapters trace the intellectual history of particular fields of development: gender and development, natural resource management and environmentalism and the rise of NGOs. Ruth Pearson's chapter on the rise of gender and development traces the history of the discourse from its institutional and academic beginnings to its widespread positioning in contemporary development studies. This journey begins with an understanding of gender and development as a critical intervention into a predominantly masculinist discourse and ends with the mainstreaming of gender into development policy and practice. The author highlights some of the difficulties in moving gender and development studies forward which are posed by the recent postmodern and post-development turn in some academic writing in the field, as well as the institutional pressures to dissolve gender within more generalized categories of (in)equality and exclusion. The chapter concludes that in spite of its apparent success in terms of institutional development practice, radical gender analysis has yet to be acknowledged in key sites of development analysis and policy within the global context of development.

Phil Woodhouse and Admos Chimhowu's chapter similarly follows the origins and genealogy of a global issue that has become increasingly significant in development studies. Drawing on the authors' experience in southern and West Africa, the chapter traces the discourse of natural resource management and environmentalism. It begins by considering how a colonial discourse on nature continued to influence environmental thinking at the time development studies was emerging in the 1950s and 1960s. The chapter traces the crisis of modernization since the 1970s, and the rise of environmentalism that culminated in international consensus on the need for sustainable development in the 1990s, opening spaces for a variety of environmentally informed narratives of development. It argues that the contested meanings of sustainable development reflect continuing struggles over the control of natural resources of all kinds, in which environmental narratives are used to legitimize particular agendas of social and economic change.

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The final chapter, by David Lewis, takes a personal look at the startling growth of writings within development studies on non-governmental organizations (NGOs), which began in the late 1980s. As he argues, however, NGOs were not new, but were 'discovered' by policy-makers and researchers during this period, in a process that tended to obscure a two-hundred-year history of international non-governmental public action. Furthermore, this period saw the rise of 'non-governmentalism', in which a set of unproven assumptions and often unrealistic expectations about NGOs became prevalent, driven by new policy imperatives concerning privatization and non-state actors within the wider context of neo-liberal ascendancy. The chapter contends that while valuable writings on NGOs emerged, some important problems with the 'NGO literature' resulted from all this, including normative bias, an emphasis on managerialism and a low theoretical content. NGOs remain, however, important actors in development, and the chapter concludes with some suggestions for a way forward for a critical NGO research agenda.

Taken together, the chapters in this volume challenge orthodoxies through personal histories and individual narratives to construct different, radical histories of intellectual origins, drawing upon traditions and debates that have been sidelined in mainstream international development discourse. Consequently, invoking Burawoy's matrix described above, these chapters can be located within the sphere of reflexive knowledge, which is both critical and public. They demonstrate that notwithstanding the co-optation of potentially radical discourses within a neo-liberal hegemony, which has dramatically reduced spaces of dissent and contestation, and as is evident from the writings in this volume, there remain critical voices.

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